

# Fiber-Rich Filipino Food Guide

Why fiber is your most powerful food tool — and how to get enough of it from everyday Filipino meals. Covers **kidney disease**, **diabetes**, **constipation**, **gout**, and more.



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**25 g**  
Women target / day

**38 g**  
Men target / day

**14–18 g**  
Average Filipino gets

**~30%**  
↓ Heart disease risk

**14 g**  
= 1,000 kcal rule of thumb

Most Filipinos get only 14–18 g/day — roughly half the recommended target. Adding monggo soup 3× a week can close that gap.

## 1 The Two Types of Fiber — and What Each One Does

### Soluble Fiber

Dissolves in water → forms a thick gel in your gut

**How it works:** the gel slows stomach emptying, traps bile acids (cholesterol), and buffers glucose absorption.

- ✓ **Lowers LDL cholesterol** — traps bile acids so the liver must pull LDL from blood to make new ones.
- ✓ **Flattens blood sugar spikes** — slows carb absorption after every meal.
- ✓ **Feeds gut bacteria** → they produce short-chain fatty acids (butyrate, propionate) that reduce inflammation.

*Filipino sources:* oatmeal (beta-glucan), okra (mucilage), monggo / beans (pectin), guava (pectin), chia seeds, psyllium

### Insoluble Fiber

Does NOT dissolve → adds bulk and speed to stool

**How it works:** absorbs water like a sponge, expands stool, and speeds transit through the colon.

- ✓ **Prevents and treats constipation** — softens stool, reduces straining.
- ✓ **Reduces colon cancer risk** — faster transit = less time for carcinogens to contact the colon wall.
- ✓ **Reduces uremic toxin load** — in CKD, faster transit reduces p-cresol and indoxyl sulfate production by gut bacteria.

*Filipino sources:* brown rice (bran), kamote skin, kangkong stems, corn kernels, whole wheat, sitaw, talong skin

Most whole Filipino foods contain **both types**. You don't need to track which is which — just eat a variety of whole plants every day. Whole prunes and psyllium husk contain both types in useful proportions.

## 2 Fiber's Three Jobs in Your Body

### ① Adds Bulk & Speeds Transit

Insoluble fiber absorbs water in the large intestine, expanding stool and triggering peristaltic waves. Stool moves faster → less time for toxins to sit against the colon wall.

✓ **Softer stool · Faster transit · Less cancer contact time**

### ② Slows Digestion & Absorption

Soluble fiber gel slows gastric emptying. Glucose enters the bloodstream more gradually → lower post-meal spikes. Bile acids get trapped in the gel → excreted instead of reabsorbed → liver pulls LDL from blood.

✓ **Flattens blood sugar · ↓ LDL cholesterol**

### ③ Feeds Gut Bacteria (Prebiotics)

Fiber ferments in the colon, feeding beneficial bacteria. They produce short-chain fatty acids: **butyrate** (fuels colon cells, reduces inflammation), **propionate** (tells liver to make less glucose), **acetate** (reduces appetite).

✓ **Healthy gut lining · ↓ Inflammation · ↓ Toxins in CKD**

## 3 Proven Health Benefits — What the Evidence Shows

| Condition              | What fiber does                                                                       | Evidence           | Best fiber source                           |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Heart disease          | ↓ LDL 5–10% per 5–10 g soluble fiber/day; lowers blood pressure                       | <b>Strong</b> ✓✓✓  | Oats, monggo, okra, psyllium                |
| Type 2 Diabetes        | ↓ post-meal glucose spikes; improves insulin sensitivity over time; ↓ HbA1c 0.5–1%    | <b>Strong</b> ✓✓✓  | Oats, chia, monggo, okra, sitaw             |
| Chronic Kidney Disease | ↓ uremic toxins (p-cresol, indoxyl sulfate); slows CKD progression; ↓ inflammation    | <b>Moderate</b> ✓✓ | Oats, okra, psyllium, white rice + psyllium |
| Colon cancer           | ↓ risk ~10% per 10 g/day; faster transit = less carcinogen contact time               | <b>Strong</b> ✓✓✓  | Brown rice, kamote, whole vegetables        |
| Constipation           | Softens stool; reduces straining; more effective than stool softeners alone           | <b>Strong</b> ✓✓✓  | Psyllium (C-Lium), prunes, oats + water     |
| Weight / obesity       | Increases satiety; reduces total caloric intake; ↓ visceral fat over time             | <b>Moderate</b> ✓✓ | Any high-fiber whole food; chia in water    |
| Mortality (all-cause)  | Highest fiber intake quartile → ~15–20% lower all-cause mortality vs. lowest quartile | <b>Strong</b> ✓✓✓  | Whole grains + legumes + vegetables daily   |

THE FIBER MYTH — WHAT MOST PATIENTS GET WRONG

"A big green salad ≈ 2–3 g fiber. ½ cup monggo soup ≈ 8 g fiber. 1 medium guava ≈ 5 g fiber. Fiber ≠ volume of vegetables eaten."

| Food (Filipino name)                                                     | Standard Serving   | Fiber | K level   | P level    | CKD / Dialysis Note                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-------|-----------|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| VERY HIGH — ≥ 8 G FIBER PER SERVING · POWERHOUSE CHOICES                 |                    |       |           |            |                                                                                                    |
| Black beans (itim na beans, boiled)                                      | ½ cup cooked       | 15 g  | HIGH      | HIGH       | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: Limit — leach before cooking, discuss amount with dietitian                    |
| Garbanzos / chickpeas (boiled)                                           | ½ cup cooked       | 12 g  | HIGH      | HIGH       | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: Limit — high K and P; OK in small portions in earlier CKD                      |
| Chia seeds                                                               | 2 tbsp (28 g)      | 10 g  | LOW       | MOD        | Generally kidney-friendly in 1–2 tbsp doses; stir into lugaw, water, or oatmeal                    |
| Avocado / abokado (whole fruit)                                          | 1 whole            | 10 g  | VERY HIGH | LOW        | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: limit to ½ avocado — very high potassium despite low phosphorus                |
| Monggo / mung beans (boiled)                                             | ½ cup cooked       | 8 g   | MOD       | MOD        | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: limit portion; leach by boiling in fresh water; OK 2× / week                   |
| Prunes / dried plums                                                     | 5–6 pieces (100 g) | 7 g   | HIGH      | MOD        | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: limit to 2–3 pieces — high potassium; good constipation remedy for earlier CKD |
| HIGH — 4–7 G FIBER PER SERVING · EXCELLENT EVERYDAY CHOICES              |                    |       |           |            |                                                                                                    |
| Guava / bayabas (with skin)                                              | 1 medium           | 5 g   | MOD       | LOW        | CKD 4–5 / dialysis: moderate K — limit to ½ guava; earlier CKD: excellent daily fruit              |
| Saluyot / jute leaves (cooked)                                           | 1 cup cooked       | 5 g   | LOW       | LOW        | Very kidney-friendly — low K and P; excellent leafy green for dialysis patients                    |
| Oatmeal / rolled oats (cooked)                                           | 1 cup cooked       | 4 g   | LOW       | LOW        | Best staple carb for CKD + diabetes; beta-glucan lowers LDL; kidney-safe at 1 cup/day              |
| Oat bran                                                                 | ½ cup cooked       | 6–8 g | LOW       | LOW        | Highest beta-glucan per gram; use in porridge or mix with oatmeal; kidney-friendly                 |
| Flaxseed / linseed (ground)                                              | 2 tbsp             | 5–6 g | LOW       | MOD        | Use ground form for absorption; omega-3 bonus; safe in CKD 1–3; limit in CKD 4–5                   |
| Brown rice                                                               | 1 cup cooked       | 3.5 g | LOW       | SLIGHTLY ↑ | CKD: slightly more P than white rice; OK in CKD 1–3; white rice + psyllium preferred in CKD 4–5    |
| MODERATE — 2–4 G FIBER PER SERVING · GOOD CONTRIBUTORS TO DAILY TOTAL    |                    |       |           |            |                                                                                                    |
| Okra (steamed or in sinigang)                                            | 1 cup cooked       | 3.2 g | LOW       | LOW        | Safest high-fiber vegetable for CKD/dialysis; viscous mucilage also lowers blood sugar             |
| Kamote / sweet potato (boiled)                                           | 1 medium (150 g)   | 3.8 g | MOD–HIGH  | LOW        | Boil and drain; leach in large water — reduces K by 30–50%; baking raises K; OK in CKD 1–3         |
| Saba banana (boiled, slightly unripe)                                    | 1 medium           | 3.5 g | MOD       | LOW        | CKD 4–5: limit 1 piece; unripe = higher resistant starch + lower sugar + lower K than ripe         |
| Malunggay / moringa leaves (cooked)                                      | 1 cup              | 3.5 g | LOW       | LOW        | Low K and P; anti-inflammatory; excellent in tinola, sinigang, and monggo; safe for CKD/dialysis   |
| Sitaw / yard-long beans (cooked)                                         | 1 cup cooked       | 3 g   | LOW       | LOW        | Low K and P; kidney-safe; pairs well with fish and rice; good everyday vegetable                   |
| Sampaloc / tamarind pulp (eaten)                                         | ¼ cup pulp         | 3–5 g | HIGH      | LOW        | Only if pulp is eaten — strained sinigang broth = 0 g fiber. High K in pulp; limit in CKD 4–5      |
| Kangkong / water spinach (ginisa)                                        | 1 cup cooked       | 2.5 g | LOW       | LOW        | Safe for CKD/dialysis; good daily leafy green; sauté in small canola oil + garlic                  |
| Pako / fern salad                                                        | 1 cup              | 2.5 g | LOW       | LOW        | Low K; generally safe; eat with vinegar-garlic dressing (no bagoong in CKD)                        |
| LOW — < 2 G FIBER PER SERVING · COUNT THESE AS BONUSES, NOT MAIN SOURCES |                    |       |           |            |                                                                                                    |
| Eggplant / talong (cooked)                                               | 1 cup cooked       | 2.5 g | LOW       | LOW        | Low K and P; kidney-safe; good in pinakbet and kare-kare                                           |
| Pechay / bok choy (cooked)                                               | 1 cup cooked       | 2.5 g | LOW       | LOW        | Low K and P; very kidney-safe; good in sinigang and soups                                          |
| Papaya / hinog na papaya                                                 | 1 cup chunks       | 2.5 g | LOW–MOD   | LOW        | Low K; enzyme papain may aid digestion; OK for most CKD stages in normal portions                  |
| Pineapple / pinya (fresh)                                                | 1 cup chunks       | 2.3 g | LOW       | LOW        | Low K; bromelain enzyme; OK for CKD in moderation; avoid canned in syrup                           |
| Psyllium husk (C-Lium)                                                   | 1 tsp in water     | 3–5 g | NONE      | NONE       | Best supplement for CKD/dialysis — zero K and P; take with 250 mL water at mealtime                |
| White rice (kanin)                                                       | 1 cup cooked       | 0.6 g | LOWEST    | LOWEST     | Lowest K and P of all staples — dialysis-safe; add psyllium or eat with monggo for fiber boost     |

K = potassium · P = phosphorus · Avocado value is for whole fruit · Sampaloc: 3–5 g only if pulp is eaten — strained sinigang broth = 0 g fiber · Leaching: boil in large volume water, discard water, repeat once — reduces potassium 30–50%.

Fiber IS Recommended

Chronic Kidney Disease (CKD)

Fiber reduces uremic toxins **p-cresol and indoxyl sulfate** — produced when gut bacteria ferment undigested protein. These toxins accelerate CKD progression and worsen cardiovascular risk.

- **CKD Stage 1–3:** Eat normally from the full fiber table. Aim for 25–38 g/day. Monggo, okra, oats, and saluyot are excellent.
- **CKD Stage 4–5 / Pre-dialysis:** Check potassium. Low-K fiber options: **oats, psyllium husk (C-Lium), okra, kangkong, white rice + psyllium, pechay, saluyot.** Limit monggo, avocado, guava portions.
- **On Dialysis:** Same low-K rules. Psyllium and shirataki rice are ideal — zero potassium, zero phosphorus. Leach all vegetables before cooking.
- **How to leach:** Peel, slice thin, boil in large volume of water 15 min, drain, cook normally. Reduces K by 30–50%.

Best Dietary Tool for DM

Type 2 Diabetes

Soluble fiber is your single most powerful food tool. It slows carb absorption at **every meal**, flattening the glucose curve. Every gram counts.

- **Before or during meals:** oats, monggo, okra, chia — eaten before rice for maximum blunting effect.
- **3 g of beta-glucan/day** (≈ 1 cup cooked oatmeal + ½ cup okra) is recognized for cholesterol reduction and glucose modulation.
- **High-fiber meals reduce insulin resistance** over time — this is above and beyond the per-meal spike reduction.
- **Chia seeds:** 1 tbsp stirred into water 30 min before a meal → slows gastric emptying → blunts post-meal glucose rise.
- **Do NOT** count fruit juice as fiber — even fresh juice removes the fiber. Eat whole fruit.

Fiber + Water = Solution

Constipation

- **Best remedy: psyllium husk** (1 tsp in 250 mL water, 1–2× daily) — works as well as prescription laxatives in clinical trials. Must drink adequate water.
- **Whole prunes (5–6 pieces):** 7 g fiber + sorbitol → draws water into colon. As effective as psyllium. **CKD 4–5: limit to 2–3 pieces (high K).**
- **Prune juice:** only partly works — 2–3 g fiber, no sorbitol effect. Do NOT count toward daily fiber target.
- **Melon milk (pakwan + gatas):** NOT a remedy — melon is 90% water with <1 g fiber per cup. Adding milk gives protein, not fiber. Will not relieve constipation.
- Always increase fiber slowly (+5 g/week) and drink 8+ glasses of water/day. Going too fast causes bloating.

Legumes Are Safe — Keep Eating Them

Gout

**MYTH:** "Avoid monggo and beans — they cause gout."

**FACT:** Dietary purines in legumes have **minimal effect** on uric acid versus alcohol, fructose, and red meat. Large studies show legume intake does NOT significantly raise serum uric acid or gout attack rates.

- Monggo, beans, chickpeas — keep eating them for their fiber and protein benefits.
- **True gout triggers to reduce:** beer/alcohol, sweetened drinks (fructose), organ meats (liver, kidney), shellfish, red meat in excess.
- Higher fiber intake is associated with **lower uric acid levels** — possibly via improved insulin sensitivity and gut microbiome effects.

Fiber Prevents New Pockets

Diverticulosis / Diverticulitis

**MYTH:** "Avoid nuts and seeds if you have diverticulosis."

**FACT:** Old advice — now reversed. High fiber intake actually **prevents** new diverticula and reduces flare-up risk. Seeds and nuts are fine during remission.

- During an **acute flare (diverticulitis):** temporarily reduce insoluble fiber until inflammation settles, then gradually reintroduce.
- Long-term: aim for 25–38 g/day. Brown rice, whole vegetables, and oats are ideal maintenance foods.

Insoluble Fiber Helps

Kidney Stones (Calcium Oxalate)

Insoluble fiber binds oxalate in the gut **before** it is absorbed — reducing urinary oxalate, the main building block of calcium oxalate stones.

- Whole grains (brown rice, kamote) and non-starchy vegetables eaten **with meals** reduce oxalate absorption.
- **Do NOT restrict calcium** — calcium in food also binds gut oxalate. Low calcium intake paradoxically increases stone risk.
- Avoid spinach, kamote leaves, and star fruit (balimbing) — very high oxalate content regardless of fiber.
- Drink 2.5–3 L water/day — more important than fiber alone for stone prevention.

How to Safely Increase Your Fiber Intake — The 5-Step Plan

1

Add 5 g per week

Never jump from 14 g to 38 g overnight. Add one new fiber source per week. Gut bacteria need 2–4 weeks to adapt. Too fast = bloating and gas.

2

Drink 8+ glasses water

Fiber without water can cause constipation, not relieve it. Every gram of fiber needs water to do its job. Always increase both together.

3

Start with oats + okra

The easiest pair for most Filipinos: ½ cup oatmeal (4 g) + 1 cup okra in sinigang (3 g) = 7 g before lunch — kidney-safe for all CKD stages.

4

Swap rice 3× / week

Replace ½ cup white rice with ½ cup monggo soup 3× per week: adds 16–24 g fiber per week without changing the rest of your diet.

5

Add psyllium at meals

1 tsp C-Lium (psyllium) stirred into a glass of water at each meal adds 3–5 g soluble fiber per dose — zero potassium, safe for dialysis.

🍽️ Sample Filipino Fiber Day — How 25–38 g Looks in Real Meals

| Meal        | Food                                                                                                      | Fiber | Running total | CKD Safe?                                                  |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Breakfast   | ½ cup rolled oats cooked with water (lugaw-style, no condensed milk) + 1 boiled egg + black barako coffee | 4 g   | 4 g           | ✓ All CKD                                                  |
| Mid-morning | 1 medium guava (eaten with skin) + water                                                                  | 5 g   | 9 g           | ⚠️ CKD4–5: ½ only                                          |
| Lunch       | ½ cup monggo guisado + ½ cup brown rice + 1 cup kangkong ginisa (canola oil, no bagoong)                  | 14 g  | 23 g          | ⚠️ CKD4–5: limit monggo, use white rice + psyllium instead |
| Afternoon   | 1 tbsp chia seeds stirred into water or calamansi juice (unsweetened)                                     | 5 g   | 28 g ✓W       | ✓ All CKD (small dose)                                     |
| Dinner      | Sautéed okra + sitaw with grilled galunggong + ½ cup corn (nilagang mais)                                 | 8 g   | 36 g ✓M       | ✓ All CKD                                                  |

✓W = Women's target met (25 g)   ✓M = Men's target met (38 g)   ⚠️ CKD 4–5 / Dialysis: swap monggo for okra + psyllium; swap guava for pechay or saluyot; use white rice + 1 tsp psyllium in water instead of brown rice.

Fiber Supplements — When Food Alone Is Not Enough

| Supplement                   | Fiber / dose   | Fiber type            | CKD / Dialysis       | How to use · Key notes                                                                                                                                              |
|------------------------------|----------------|-----------------------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Psyllium husk (C-Lium Fiber) | 3–5 g / 1 tsp  | Soluble + insoluble   | ✓ Safe ALL stages    | Best all-round supplement. Stir 1 tsp in 250 mL water at meals. Evidence base: lowers LDL, treats constipation, helps CKD uremic toxins. Must drink adequate water. |
| Chia seeds                   | 10 g / 2 tbsp  | Soluble + insoluble   | ⚠️ ≤1 tbsp in CKD4–5 | Stir into lugaw, water, or oatmeal. Omega-3 bonus. Soak for 15 min first — forms gel. Some phosphorus — limit dose in dialysis.                                     |
| Oat bran                     | 6–8 g / ½ cup  | Soluble (beta-glucan) | ✓ Safe all CKD       | Highest beta-glucan per gram. Cook as porridge or mix into oatmeal. 3 g beta-glucan/day recognized for LDL reduction. Low K and P.                                  |
| Flaxseed (ground)            | 5–6 g / 2 tbsp | Soluble + insoluble   | ⚠️ Limit in CKD 4–5  | Use ground — whole seeds pass undigested. Omega-3 (ALA) bonus. Store in fridge to prevent rancidity. Moderate phosphorus.                                           |
| Shirataki (konjac) rice      | ~1 g / cup     | Glucomannan (soluble) | ✓ Ideal for dialysis | Near-zero K and P. Good rice substitute for dialysis patients. Rinse thoroughly. Very filling. Lowers post-meal glucose significantly.                              |

Key Takeaways — What to Remember

Your 5 Most Important Foods

These 5 foods alone can get most Filipinos to their fiber target: **oats · guava · monggo · chia seeds · okra**. Add one per day and build from there.

The Biggest Insight

A big green salad = 2–3 g fiber. Half cup of monggo soup = 8 g fiber. **Fiber is about the right foods — not the volume of vegetables eaten.** Focus on beans, legumes, and whole grains.

Replace, Don't Add

The easiest change: replace ½ cup white rice with ½ cup monggo soup **3× per week**. This one swap adds 16–24 g fiber per week — enough to meaningfully change your health outcomes.

⚠️ CKD and Dialysis Patients — Safe Fiber First

- **Best options (low K, low P):** psyllium husk (C-Lium), oats, okra, saluyot, kangkong, pechay, white rice + psyllium, shirataki rice.
- **Limit (check with dietitian):** monggo, avocado, guava, kamote, saba banana — all moderately high in potassium.
- **Avoid in CKD 4–5:** black beans (large portions), prunes (more than 2–3 pieces), full avocado.
- **Leach all vegetables:** boil in large water 15 min, drain, cook normally — reduces K 30–50%.

Constipation Myths Debunked

- **Melon milk:** melon is 90% water — NOT a fiber remedy. Will not relieve constipation.
- **Prune juice:** only partly works. Most fiber removed during juicing. Do not count toward daily fiber target.
- **What actually works:** whole prunes (5–6 pieces) or psyllium husk (1 tsp in water) — both supported by clinical trials. Always with 8+ glasses water daily.